

Unfortunately, though devices of the 802.11b and 802.11g standards can co-exist in the same network, you are bound to see a huge drop in performance when a slower 802.11b device connects to your network. The hardware is designed to shift into slower modes when interacting with a slower device. Thus, introducing an 802.11b device into a network of 802.11g devices, is in effect the same as running an 802.11b network.

Will being near a WLAN for a prolonged period of time give me brain cancer, like with mobiles?

Not unless you stick your head into a fileserver cabinet that has multiple wireless cards, and keep your head in there for a decade or two. Though, the laws of probability dictate that stressing over such things might get to you first. A wireless card or access point emits the same signals as your microwave oven and cell phone, but the signals are about a 100 to 1,000 times weaker. Moreover, wireless devices emit signals irregularly, only when data is transferred, while cell phones emit signals, and thus radiation, constantly, so long as they're powered on. These signals increase in strength when you receive or make a call. So in short, you are about a 100 to 1,000 times safer being exposed to wireless devices than you are with your cell phone.

My laptop has a weak wireless card, and I have to be really close to an access point to get a signal. How do I increase its range?

If your laptop's wireless card has the option to attach an external antenna, you should do that. You can tell whether this option is available to you by looking for a jack similar to a headphone or microphone jack. If your laptop does not support this antenna extension, you can always add a USB wireless network adapter with a decent external antenna.

